
The Founder Bottleneck Audit

Every decision that runs through you is a tax on your business. This worksheet helps you find them, cost them, and cut them.

THE PROBLEM

You built the business. You know it best. So naturally, people ask you, and naturally, you answer. That pattern made sense at £5. It's quietly straining growth once the business passes £500k.

The constraint isn't your team, and it isn't the market. It's the invisible queue of decisions, approvals and sign-offs waiting for your attention every day, while you wonder why growth is hard to buy back. The gap isn't that you're the bottleneck personally, it's that the operational infrastructure hasn't kept pace with the business.

WHAT THE DATA ACTUALLY SAYS

- **Founder time allocation.** CEOs studied worked 62.5 hours a week on average, with 72% of their time spent in meetings and their own agenda advanced only 43% of the time. (*Harvard Business Review*)
- **Reactive vs proactive time.** About 36% of CEO time was spent in reactive mode, handling unfolding issues, internal and external. (*Harvard Business Review*)
- **Decision-making inefficiency.** 61% of executives say at least half the time spent on decision-making is ineffective, costing a typical Fortune 500 company an estimated \$250 million a year in wasted management time. (*McKinsey & Company*)

A significant share of that time is decisions and approvals that should never reach your desk.

STEP 1: TRACK EVERY APPROVAL FOR FIVE DAYS

Run this for five working days. Be honest, and log it as it happens, not from memory at the end of the day.

DAY	WHAT WAS IT?	HOW LONG DID IT SIT WAITING ON YOU?	DID IT ACTUALLY NEED TO BE YOU?
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			

DAY	WHAT WAS IT?	HOW LONG DID IT SIT WAITING ON YOU?	DID IT ACTUALLY NEED TO BE YOU?
Thu			
Fri			

STEP 2: THE THREE-QUESTION AUDIT

1. What got delayed because it waited for you? List every project or decision that sat in limbo, not because the team couldn't act, but because they were waiting on you.

2. What did you approve that you didn't need to see? Invoices under a threshold. Supplier responses. If the outcome was the same whether you saw it or not, that's a bottleneck.

3. What do people ask you that they already know the answer to? This is the most expensive category. It means the team doesn't trust their own judgement, usually because they've never been given the framework to use it.

If you answered yes to any of these, you've found your bottleneck.

THE INSIGHT

The real issue isn't delegation, it's doctrine. Your team isn't asking for approval because they're unconfident. They're asking because they don't know what "good" looks like without you in the room. The fix isn't handing things off, it's codifying the judgement you carry in your head.

STEP 3: WRITE THE RULE

Take your top three recurring approvals from Step 1 and write a one-page decision rule for each.

Recurring approval #1: _____ **Trigger (when does this rule apply):** _____ **Threshold or criteria:** _____ **Who decides without you:** _____ What "good enough" looks like: _____

Recurring approval #2: _____ **Trigger:** _____ **Threshold or criteria:** _____ **Who decides without you:** _____ What "good enough" looks like: _____

Recurring approval #3: _____ **Trigger:** _____ **Threshold or criteria:** _____ **Who decides without you:** _____ What "good enough" looks like: _____

WHAT TO DO THIS WEEK

→ **Track every approval for five days.** Write down what it was, how long it took, and whether it actually needed to be you.

→ **Pick your top three recurring approvals and write a one-page decision rule for each.** When to do X, when not to, what "good enough" looks like.

→ **Set a financial threshold your team can act within without asking.** The number matters less than having one.

THE CLOSING QUESTION

If you were unavailable for 48 hours, what would grind to a halt? That list is your audit.

Want a structured, tracked way to work through what this surfaces, not just this list but the other eight areas most founder-led agencies never get to? [Take the free VOS assessment](#) or [book a discovery call](#).

Sources used: Harvard Business Review · McKinsey & Company. All statistics cited as reported, no figures invented or interpolated.

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